WELLBEING SCIENCE

The Fun Habit

How the Pursuit of Joy and Wonder Can Change Your Life

Mike Rucker, PhD · 2023

A behavioral scientist argues that fun isn't frivolous. It's a skill you can plan and practice, and making room for it can change how you feel about your whole life.[1,2]

WHY READ IT

- A playful, research-backed case for taking fun seriously[2,3]
- Simple tools for finding fun in ordinary days[3]
- A warm reminder that life is short, so enjoy it on purpose[2]

GET THE BOOK



The Fun Habit by Mike Rucker, PhD

Atria Books (Simon & Schuster), 2023. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *The Fun Habit* by Mike Rucker, PhD. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

Do fun, don't chase happiness

Rucker separates chasing happiness as a feeling, which often backfires, from doing fun things, which you can actually choose. He also points to research suggesting that feeling good now makes it easier to choose harder, longer-term activities later.[2,3,4]

THREE LESSONS

1 **Audit your time**

Most of us don't know where our hours go. Rucker recommends a time audit to find room for fun that's already there.[5]

2 **Keep a Fun File**

A ready list of 8 to 15 go-to fun options, so free time doesn't default to scrolling.[2,5]

3 **Fun is a choice**

Fun rarely happens after the work is done. It happens when you plan for it like anything else that matters.[2,3]

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THE FRAMEWORK

The PLAY Model[6]

Sort your activities on two axes: challenge (what they cost you) and fun (how much you enjoy them).[6]

1 Pleasing

Low challenge, high fun

Easy and enjoyable. Rucker treats these as the everyday goal.[6]

Try: Build them into your routine.

2 Living

High challenge, high fun

Peak experiences that take effort or risk. Not daily, but worth real space in your life.[6]

Try: Plan a few each year.

3 Agonizing

High challenge, low fun

Costly and unpleasant. Some, like taxes, can't be avoided.[6]

Try: Eliminate what you can.

4 Yielding

Low challenge, low fun

Easy but empty habits that quietly eat time.[6]

Try: Swap them for something Pleasing.

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

SAVOR

Rucker's five tools for more fun in ordinary days.[3,7]

1. Story editing: retell the story you tell about your time (an idea from Timothy Wilson).[8]
2. Activity bundling: pair a must-do with a want-to.[9]
3. Variable hedonics and Options: add variety and keep fun choices ready.
4. Reminiscing: revisit good memories on purpose.

Time audit and PLAY sort

Combining two of the book's tools.[5,6]

1. Log yesterday hour by hour.
2. Place each activity in a PLAY quadrant.
3. Find one Yielding activity to swap for something from your Fun File.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Do a time audit for one day.
2. Sort it with the PLAY model.
3. Start a Fun File and trim it to 8 to 15 options.
4. Put one Pleasing activity on the calendar.

REFLECT

Which quadrant does most of your free time fall into?

What reliably makes you lose track of time in a good way?

Try it in Sedi: Keep your Fun File as a note in Brainly, and put one Pleasing activity on this week's calendar in Timely.

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🎈 The Fun Habit

Mike Rucker, PhD · Atria Books (Simon & Schuster) · 2023

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Mike Rucker, PhD or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

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